

The Boston Globe

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SATURDAY, MAY 2, 2026

The volume of calls has risen to an average of **20,000 a day** in recent months, being answered by 645 SNAP caseworkers.

Many in Mass. lose food aid as calls overwhelm system

New rules force more and longer conversations making it hard to keep up

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

At a time when a record number of Massachusetts households say they don't have enough to eat, local enrollment in the federal government's main food assistance program is plummeting at nearly double the national rate. The decline in people getting assistance is being caused in part by the state's inability to handle the need, advocates said. More than three-

quarters of calls concerning the federal Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, or SNAP, are being disconnected before a caseworker is free to answer, according to data obtained by the Massachusetts Law Reform Institute, a poverty law and policy center. SNAP rolls are falling across the country — likely because of attempts to bring down payment error rates — but the 80,000-household decrease in Massachusetts, which includes nearly 50,000 children, is striking. And it includes eligible families who shouldn't have been terminated. Callers trying to reach the Department of Transitional Assistance to report changes or **SNAP, Page A6**

Critics decry prisons' partnership with ICE

Review shows few targeted for deportation were already incarcerated

By Laura Crimaldi and Scooty Nickerson
GLOBE STAFF

The Trump administration returned to power vowing an immigration crackdown that would prioritize arresting the "worst of the worst" Yet relatively few of those offenders are housed in the Massachusetts Department of Correction, the only agency in the state willing to partner with US Immigration and Customs Enforce-

ment in its deportation efforts, according to a Globe analysis of prison data. Between 2009 and last year, the state Department of Correction transferred about 2,000 noncitizens into ICE custody, or less than 2 percent of the nearly 130,000 people freed from Massachusetts prisons, figures show. The small number of transfers offers another measurement of how President Trump's deportation push has fallen heavily on

noncitizens who don't have serious criminal records. In the first year of Trump's new term, 90 DOC inmates were transferred to ICE custody, compared to 86 in 2024, the last year of the Biden administration. By contrast, federal immigration enforcement in Massachusetts since last year shows an explosion in activity, with ICE arresting over 7,000 people between Trump's inauguration on Jan. 20, 2025, and March 10, 2026, according to data from the Deportation Data Project. The 2025 figures show the **ICE, Page A7**

Where the water goes

The Deer Island plant is a marvel of modernity, and it doesn't even smell bad



PHOTOS BY DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Everything that goes down the drain for most of Metro Boston ends up at the treatment plant on Deer Island, including what is called digested sludge.

By Joshua Miller
GLOBE STAFF

DEER ISLAND — If you did dishes last week in Somerville or Cambridge or Boston, I was standing with what you washed down your sink. I had traveled to the massive waste water treatment plant for most of Metro Boston to learn what happens, exactly, to everything we flush and put down the drain. And when I arrived on this Boston Harbor island, I was shocked to find it didn't stink; fresh sea air was the only scent on the breeze. That was the first of many surprises I encountered at the Deer Island Wastewater Treatment Plant. There was one marvel of modernity after another, a mind-bogglingly vast unseen system that cleans your waste and sends it out to sea,

REPORTER'S NOTEBOOK



engineering and science front to back. Or as Chad A. Whiting, the director of the plant and my knowledgeable tour guide, succinctly put it: "It's all chemistry." Say you live in an apartment in Somerville near Inman, flush the toilet, take a shower, and wash some dishes. The water **WASTE WATER, Page A10**

A federal appeals court has restricted access to one of the most common means of abortion in the US by blocking mailing of prescriptions of mifepristone. **A6.**

President Trump rejected Iran's latest proposal to end the war between the countries. **A4.**

The state Office of the Chief Medical Examiner amended its finding that Sandra Birchmore killed herself and listed her manner of death as "undetermined." **B1.**



Indoor choices

Saturday: Cloudy, cooler. High: 54-59. Low: 43-48.
Sunday: Morning rain. High: 56-61. Low: 41-46.
Sunrise: 5:38 Sunset: 7:45
Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**
Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 309, NO. 122

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



0 947725 4

Wu considers charging drivers to enter Boston

By Kate Selig
GLOBE STAFF

How do you get fewer people to drive into Boston? Charge them. That idea, known as congestion pricing, is one of several new policies Mayor Michelle Wu wants to explore as part of an ambitious, if controversial, push to reduce the city's carbon emissions. Every day, hordes of commuters stream into Boston, spewing planet-warming green-

house gases from their cars. In order for Boston to meet its climate goals, Wu says, the city has to persuade many of them to travel another way. She said she wants to explore several possible strategies for doing that, including other tolls and parking fees. The congestion pricing proposal, part of a new climate action plan the city released Monday, drew swift backlash from business groups and Wu's political foes. Meanwhile, transit advocates and climate experts

Mayor's climate plan includes review of congestion pricing

pointed to New York City's congestion charge, which was instituted last year, as proof that the policy can succeed. In a radio appearance this week, Wu emphasized that the city isn't enacting congestion pricing, just exploring it. Boston needs to weigh every possible tool to combat climate change and improve public transportation access, she said. "It can be a win-win if we know we can deliver on it," Wu told GBH's "Boston Public Ra-

dio" program on Tuesday. Supporters say congestion pricing does more than just cut emissions: It can ease gridlock, improve air quality, and make streets safer. In New York, the program has succeeded in cutting traffic and raising revenue, bolstering hopes that a similar approach could work here. Wu's new climate action plan charts a path for the city to meet its goal of slashing emissions in half by 2030. When it comes to **CONGESTION, Page A10**

UMass lecturer says support for Palestinians cost him role

Suit claims pressure from White House blocked advancement

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

A lecturer at the University of Massachusetts Amherst alleges that he was unfairly pushed out of consideration for a tenure-track role in Middle East studies because the school capitulated to pressure from the Trump White House. In an April lawsuit, Mohammad Ataie, a vocal supporter of Palestinian rights, accused UMass and two senior administrators of removing him from the job search after he was poised to be offered the promotion to professor. When the federal government scaled

up its attacks on universities partly in the name of fighting antisemitism last year, Ataie alleged, UMass administrators no longer saw him as a viable candidate because of "his teaching about, and personal advocacy for, controversial political positions" on Palestine. His lawyers wrote that Ataie's experience was part of a broader "illegal crackdown" on speech at the school. UMass spokesperson Emily Gest wrote in a statement that faculty hiring at the university was "grounded in academic excellence" and that "diverse perspectives are welcomed and debated." In court filings, the university criticized Ataie for his "heavy reliance on speculation, conjecture, and fundamentally inaccurate information." His "free speech retaliation claims have so little **UMASS, Page A5**

END OF THE ROAD



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

The Bruins needed to win Game 6 Friday night at home against the Sabres to force a Game 7 but were outplayed again in a 4-1 loss, eliminating them from the playoffs in the first round. **C1.**